

WHY WE ARE TALKING

India steps away from the Big Bang approach and opts for an incremental strategy to re-engage with Pakistan in a bid to assuage global concerns

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As an initiative this is not as big as Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's Sharm el-Sheikh move in July last year when he agreed to delink action on terrorism with the composite dialogue in talks with his Pakistani counterpart Yousuf Raza Gilani. Seven months later, India appears to be moving with extreme caution. Instead of summitry—the so-called Big Bang approach—it has proposed that the two foreign secretaries meet as a start. In chess, this would be the equivalent of an opening gambit.

The offer for talks at this juncture took even Pakistan by surprise. On January 28, at the London conference on Afghanistan, the foreign ministers of the two countries were still at loggerheads. Six days later, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) announced that it was offering foreign secretary-level talks with Pakistan. Nirupama Rao, India's foreign secretary, then met Shahid Malik, Pakistan's envoy to India, and proposed two dates, February 18 or 25. With speculation over what exactly was to be discussed, the MEA informally clarified that it was not a resumption of the composite dialogue even though Pakistan wanted it. Instead, India had offered talks on terrorism and—in a seeming concession to Pakistan—on

INDIA'S STRATEGY

WHY NOW?

Pressure was mounting from international interlocutors to begin dialogue with Pakistan as Islamabad was creating hysteria over tensions with India.

HOW WILL IT HELP?

India will deflect criticism that it was being obdurate in not talking to Pakistan. Also, a dialogue would help bolster the civilian government in Pakistan and give India a chance to assess its mettle.

THE BIG WORRY

Pakistan may get emboldened as India has agreed to talks without any tangible gains on the terrorism front. The terror situation is worsening and another attack may mean the end of the process.